

LIVE

Learning Space

NEWSPAPER

11th January, 2018

ITEM WISE EDITORIALS

2nd WEEK



UNITED NATIONS



MYANMAR ... PRESS FREEDOM

UPSC CSE – GS II

GS II ... INDIA AND ITS NEIGHBOURHOOD RELATIONS



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LIVE



NEWSPAPER EDITORIALS

... DISCUSSION

11th JANUARY, 2018

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A difficult year

Besides the Rohingya crisis, Myanmar is under scrutiny on press freedoms and the Panglong peace process



NEHGINPAO KIPGEN

For Myanmar, 2018 may be crucial. The year 2017 did not proceed favourably for either the civilian government or the military establishment, which continues to hold considerable power over state institutions. Three important issues attracted the attention of the international community – the threat to press freedom; the Rohingya refugee crisis; and the peace process with the country's ethnic armed groups. The civilian government led by the National League for Democracy (NLD), which came to power after winning a majority in the 2015 elections, attracted severe criticism for its failure to act on these issues more effectively.

As regards the first issue, evidence on the ground suggests that media freedom was threatened on several occasions. At least 11 journalists – both Myanmar and foreign – were arrested. Two journalists working for the Turkish Radio and Television Corporation – Lau Hon Meng from Singapore and Mok Choy Lin from Malaysia – were arrested in late October, along with their local interpreter, Aung Naing Soe, and driver, Hla Tin. They were charged under the country's Anti-Aircraft Act and sentenced to two months in jail for trying to use a drone to record images of the Parliament building. They were subsequently released on December 29. The issue here is not restrictions placed on the use of drones but the limited media freedom and the civilian government's reluctance or inability to act in this regard.

Reporting on Rakhine

A more serious development has been the arrest of two Reuters reporters – Wa Lone and Kyaw Soe Oo – on December 12. The Ministry of Information accuses them of “illegally acquiring information with the intention of sharing it with foreign media”. Charges have been pressed against them under the colonial-era Official Secrets Act and they face up to 14 years in prison.

At this point, details on the information they received are not known. However, it is suspected that the documents given pertained to operations of security forces in the Rakhine State. The details reportedly are about the military's investigation of a mass grave in a village called Inn Din, a mixed ethnic area, in Rakhine. Local newspapers have also reported that days after the arrest of the Reuters reporters, five ethnic Rakhine resi-

dents of Inn Din were detained on suspicion of giving them information.

The United Nations has called the crackdown in Rakhine as “ethnic cleansing” while Amnesty International has termed the operations as “crimes against humanity”. Up until now, the gruesome accounts of the actions of the security forces are primarily coming from the Rohingya refugees who have fled to neighbouring Bangladesh. But despite the continuing international condemnation, the Myanmar military leadership denies any wrongdoing and continues to maintain that they were only responding to attacks of the Arakan Rohingya Salvation Army, which they officially label as terrorist.

The third important issue that made headlines was the country's peace process with the ethnic armed groups. NLD leader Aung San Suu Kyi had said on assuming power that one of her government's top priorities was to make peace with the groups.

In May last year, the government convened the second session of the 21st Century Panglong Conference which brought together some 1,400 representatives from the government, the legislature, the military and ethnic armed organisations. It discussed 41 points and was able to reach agreement on 37 of them. The groups agreed on recognising a ‘Union’ based on democracy and federalism, with the right to self-determination. The government agreed that no ethnic race would be given special privileges. It was also decided that States and regions would be allowed to write their own Constitutions.

However, an agreement is yet to be reached on two of the most critical outstanding issues: formation of a ‘federal army’ and ‘secession’. The military, which has played a dominant role in the entire peace process, insists that there should be a single national army while the ethnic armed groups want to see a federal army, which would allow them to retain their respective armed forces.

Concerning the issue of secession, while the ethnic armed groups are willing to subscribe to the principle of non-disintegration of the Union, they would not like to see the term ‘non secession’ inserted into the Union Peace Accord. One other major concern is that out of the more than 20 armed groups, only eight have signed the Nationwide Cease-fire Agreement. The government is set to convene the third round of the Panglong Conference in the last week of January but it remains to be seen how much progress it can really make.

Nehginpaop Kipgen is assistant professor and executive director at the Center for Southeast Asian Studies, Jindal School of International Affairs, O.P.J.S. Global University

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Concerning the issue of secession, while the ethnic armed groups are willing to subscribe to the principle of non-disintegration of the Union, they would not like to see the term 'non-secession' inserted into the Union Peace Accord. One other major concern is that out of the more than 20 armed groups, only eight have signed the Nationwide Ceasefire Agreement. The government is set to convene the third round of the Panglong Conference in the last week of January but it remains to be seen how much progress it can really make.

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MYANMAR...ROHINGYAS AND PEACE PROCESS

MYANMAR AND THREE ISSUES

Civilian Government led by the National League for Democracy came to power, after winning a majority in the 2015 elections and it is under serious criticism because of the following three aspects.

- Rohingya refugee crisis.
- Threats to Press freedom.
- Delay in the peace process with the country's ethnic armed groups.

ISSUE NO.1

PRESS FREEDOM



REUTERS

- 1 At least 11 journalists were arrested. Some of them were charged under the country's Anti-Aircraft act.
- 2 Two of the Reuters reporters were accused of illegally acquiring information with the intention of sharing it with foreign media.
- 3 Charges have been pressed against them and they may face 14 years in prison.

ISSUE NO.2

NO TRANSPARENCY IN
RAKHINE STATE


UNITED NATIONS



- 1 United Nations called the crackdown in Rakhine State as “ethnic cleansing”.
- 2 Amnesty International termed the operations as crimes against humanity. So far the information with regard to the actions of the security forces are coming from the Rohingya refugees, who have fled the country.
- 3 The Myanmar military denies any wrong doing and continues to maintain that they were responding to attacks of the Arakan Rohingya Salvation Army, which they call it terrorist group.

Overall there is no clarity with regard to the situation in Rakhine Province.

INDIA

NEPAL

BANGLADESH

**Myanmar
(Burma)**

Rakhine

VIETNAM

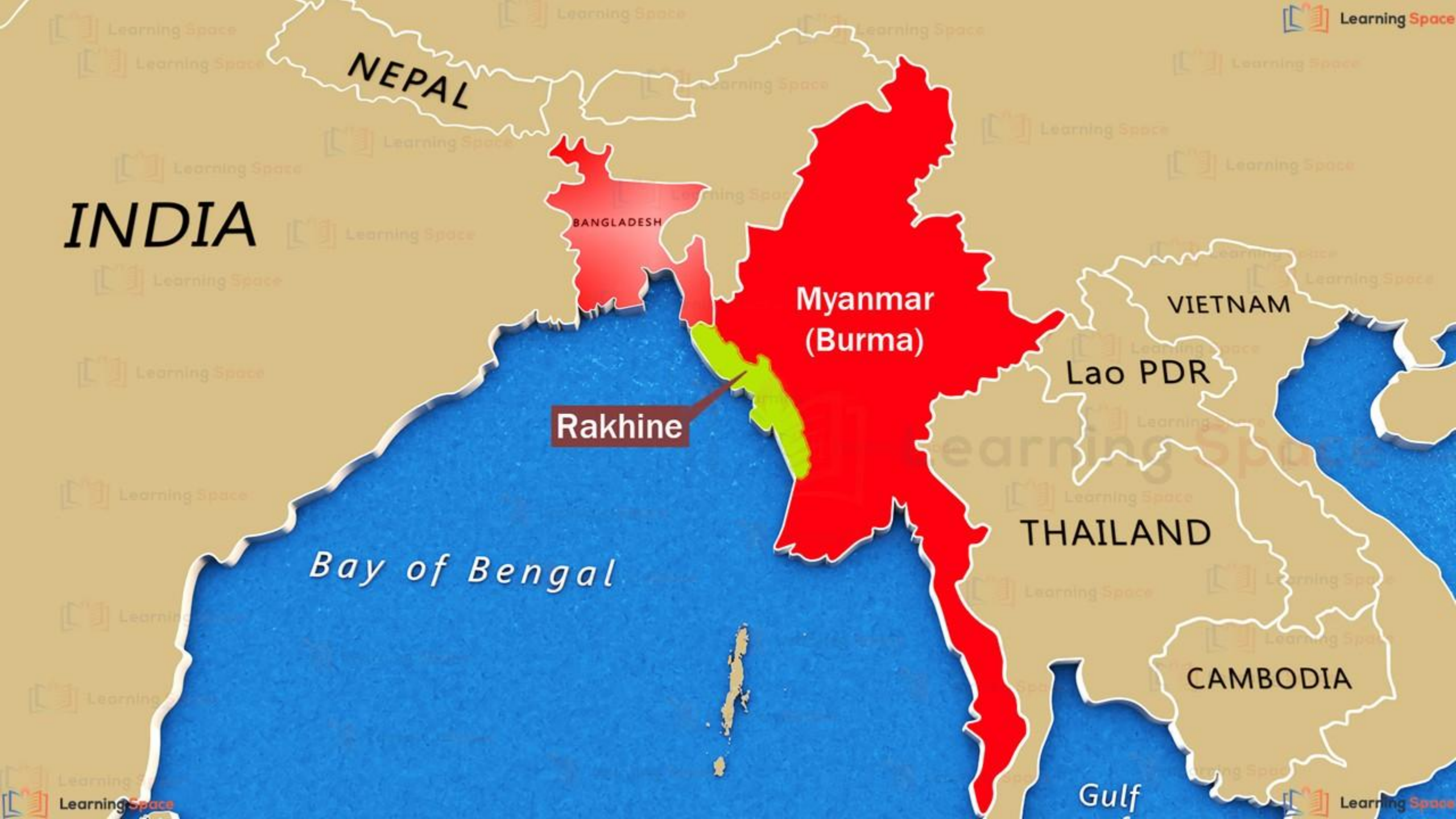
Lao PDR

THAILAND

CAMBODIA

Bay of Bengal

Gulf



ISSUE NO.3 PEACE PROCESS WITH ETHNIC GROUPS

- 1** In May 2017, the Government convened the second session of the 21st century Panglong conference. It brought together some 1400 representatives from the Government, the legislature, the military, the ethnic organisations.
- 2** The groups agreed on recognising a Union based on democracy and federalism, with the right to self determination.
- 3** The Government agreed that no ethnic race would be given special privileges. It was also decided that the States and Regions would be allowed to write their own constitution. But there is no unanimity on federal army and secession.
- 4** The military insists that there should be single national army, while the ethnic armed groups want to see a federal army, which would allow them to retain their respective armed forces.
- 5** With regard to secession, the ethnic armed groups are willing to subscribe to the principle of non disintegration of the Union, but they would not like to see the term non-secession inserted in the Union Peace Accord.

The Government is set to convene the third round of Panglong Conference in last week of January, but it remains to be seen how much progress it can really make.

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